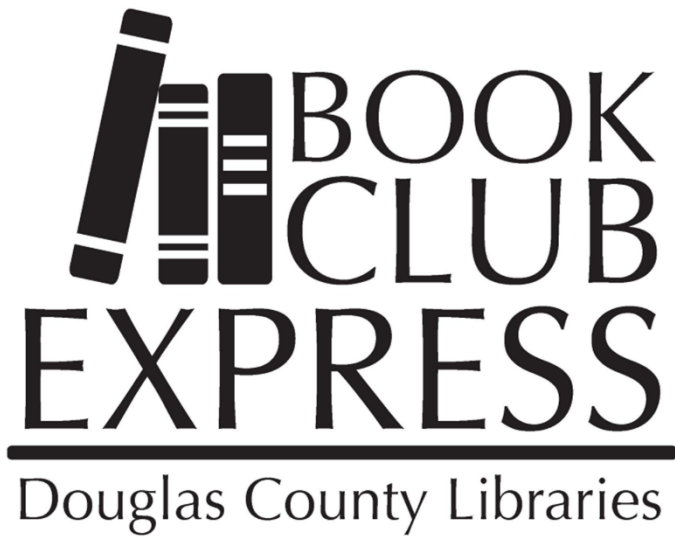




The Correspondent by Virginia Evans

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Discussion Questions

1. This story celebrates written correspondence. Describe your experience with letter writing. Do you have a special writing spot? A favorite pen? Do you write and/or save letters? Have you written a letter you've never sent? Maybe a journal serves the same purpose.
2. Sybil is retired and has deteriorating eyesight. If you are not already retired, can you envision yourself in retirement? What will bring you meaning and purpose? Explain how correspondence, even with strangers, offers Sybil a sense of connection, relevance, and purpose. She has difficulty accepting how her eye diagnosis will affect her well-being when she can no longer write or read letters. How would you cope? Is there something more proactive that Sybil can do to prepare herself?
3. How do you relate to Sybil's view of the seasons of life? Can you connect to Sybil's notion that life consists of four seasons? Which season of life are you in currently? Can you relate to her sentiment of coming in off the cold and windy road of life occasionally to find comfort? Have you experienced this? Do we recognize these times of respite in the moment or only in retrospect?
4. Grief is a strong theme throughout the story. Sybil continues to grieve and grapple with a devastating loss that happened decades earlier. Do we ever recover from deep loss, or do we learn to live with it over time? Were you surprised at Sybil's account of the tragedy? Did your view of Sybil change after she reveals the details of the accident? What are your thoughts about the unsent letter?
5. Sybil thinks of letter writing as the "original form of civility." She laments the transient nature of emails, texts, and voicemails. I remember my mother sitting down faithfully once a week to write letters to her parents. Our great-grandchildren will have few letters to treasure. Does this motivate you to write more letters? Do you think the older generation in your family would rather have a letter or a text? Do you think a handwritten note is one simple way to honor our grandparents and great-grandparents? A personal story: One of our young adult grandsons read the book *Tuesdays with Morrie*. The next week, we received an email with the subject line "Tuesdays with Grandparents." The book motivated him to value his connection with us. We've treasured this email communication every week for a few years now. I'm not sorry that it's not in handwritten form. In fact, it's almost easier to save and store in electronic folders than physical mail. Generations differ but the heartfelt intent is the same. What are your experiences with electronic versus handwritten communication? Do you save letters?
6. Do you admire Sybil and her ability to be direct or to address certain behaviors? In this case, sexism:
7. Were you worried about DM and the stalking? Did you think this was resolved in an interesting and satisfying manner?

8. What caused the strained relationship between Sybil and her daughter, Fiona? What is the best way to improve this relationship? Or is the hurt too deep? What happens when two people feel equally hurt and justified in their anger?
9. Have you submitted your DNA for analysis? Were you surprised when the story took this turn?
10. Why would Sybil, who is usually direct and initiates communication with strangers, be passive about important things like attending Daan's funeral or answering his lovely letter or visiting her daughter?
11. Have you written to an author? Which author would you write to?
12. Do you feel it's important to hear our parents' backstories? What value do backstories have for parent/adult child relationships? Do you believe apologies are important and healing? What is your opinion of Sybil's apologies?
13. 13. What threatens Sybil's strong relationship with Rosalie? Can you understand the conflict from both perspectives? Is there something to be learned from their reconciliation process? Do you consider Rosalie's actions or lack of disclosure a betrayal? Have you ever had to confront and handle betrayal?
14. What do you think of the thoughtful ways Sybil connects with others? Her eye doctor? Her neighbor? The Kindred guy? Her colleague's troubled son? Did you wonder why she has more difficulty connecting with her daughter?
15. This is not a story to be rushed through. The author thinks of the story as a puzzle that readers are slowly putting together until we reach the end and we have a complete portrait of Sybil. Was your reading experience like this? Did your first impression of Sybil change throughout the book? Do you think the author's multilayered characterization fully captures this complicated person?
16. Were you surprised by the multilayered aspect of the story? For example, sight is a curious juxtaposition. As her eyesight diminishes, her insights and understanding of relationships increase. Also, grief is an important theme of the story. For you, what is the most important message in the book? Is there an underlying theme that permeates everything else?
17. What did you think of her romantic interests? Are you Team Theodore or Team Mick? Was the resolution to this dilemma satisfactory?
18. How do you interpret the cover? Does the cover have more meaning after reading (in the last couple of pages) the last letter from Sybil? What connections did you experience in reading this story? I think that making personal connections enhances the reading experience. I connected in several ways, profoundly enhancing the story and explaining my 5-star rating and book hangover.
19. If you were to recommend *The Correspondent* to a friend or fellow reader, what superlative would you use to describe the book or your reading experience?

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Author Interview

AMY GUSTINE: What came first, the idea to write in the form of letters or wanting to deal with so many subplots and perspectives?

VIRGINIA EVANS: It started with the letters and felt like there were a few different ways to do it. You could have two corresponding people like in *84, Charing Cross Road*. You could only include outgoing letters, like in *The Color Purple* or *Dear Committee Members* by Julie Shoemaker. But I felt like including letters the main character sends as well as some she receives from a variety of corresponding partners allowed me to tell a 360° view of her life. You had to have different people to hold up the mirror at a different angle to Sybil. I'm not a meticulous planner, so I just dove in and as the book unfolded asked myself, "What does the reader need to know and who can Sybil tell it to? Or who can tell something to her?" A book of letters about an old woman runs the risk of being very very boring, so it was a question of how do you move a plot forward. But the book isn't about a plot, it's about her whole life. It has to tell the past too. I wanted to braid so many people into the book to show the vastness of her life. If she was just going to write letters to her best friend, you could only cover what was between them. If you wanted to cover her career, her current situation, her love life and who she is as a mentor and a mother, there had to be many other letter writers. For example, because Sybil is retired, to give an understanding of her career, I brought in a high school student doing a report on the judiciary who wants to interview her. There was also always this very fine line, like a dance, to make it believable that these letters are actually ones people would send—older, quainter people mostly.

AG: Our culture has moved from writing often to never writing because we talked on the phone and now we've gone back to writing with email and texting. Did having the email option make the book easier to write?

VE: Yes. Sybil is in her seventies, she's not a hundred, and she had a career, so she would e-mail, but I didn't think she ever would text. Email felt like the way to allow more relationships into her life. For example, her Garden Club isn't going to be calling every member; they're going to send a group email.

AG: So you invented the characters Sybil corresponds with dynamically, as part of the drafting process, when you needed to provide certain aspects of her life to the reader?

VE: That's exactly right. I wanted the story to be a tight ball of yarn even though there were a million strands. It had to be tight to keep a reader's interest, so there was an element of looping back almost like a coil, reminding the reader all the time of all the things that are happening and all the things that have happened. I did know that all the strands I started with had to bear on the end. Anything you put into the beginning of the book has to matter at the end. That's something we know instinctually as storytellers. When I was studying with Claire Keegan, she stressed it. Anything you put in the front end of the story has to matter at the back end or it shouldn't be there at all.

AG: Yet there will always be loose ends. In *The Correspondent*, some plot threads have to be abandoned, more or less, in medias res. For example, a troubled young man Sybil is helping, goes to college and we don't know how his life turns out. Sybil's best friend has a disabled son and a husband with dementia, but her life too persists past the pages of the book. So you have to figure out which plot threads need closure and which don't.

VE: If you think of this novel as a TV mini-series, each episode could be centered on one of Sybil's correspondents. In this book, Sybil is the center, or the sun for the planets. If you went over to Harry's life, he would be the sun and Sybil a planet. I knew that readers could only receive the edges of the other characters' stories, their lives as seen in relief against Sybil's. That's the fun of it. You could write the same kind of story about each of the other characters, but I chose Sybil to be the center.

AG: This reminds me of Julia Phillips' *Disappearing Earth*. I call that a relay novel because she hands the baton of the story off with each chapter to a new protagonist so that person becomes the center.

VE: In *Turbulence*, David Szalay does that. The book cover describes it this way: "Twelve passengers move around the globe, twelve individual lives, each in turmoil and each in some way touching the next. They circumnavigate the world in twelve plane journeys from London to Madrid, from Dakar to Sao Paulo, to Toronto, to Delhi, to Doha..." It actually moves in time with these plane trips. A character who is peripheral in one story is the center of the next story. It's so good and it's very slim, easy to read.

AG: Did you write a lot of letters that you ended up not using?

VE: No, I used most of them. In revision I added more than I deleted.

AG: Instead of exposition in dialogue, a common pitfall for newer writers, here I felt the danger was "exposition in letters," but you never fell into that trap.

VE: It's one of the big engines of the way my brain works—asking myself if it feels real. I hate the experience of pulling out of the page and thinking that would never happen or nobody would say that. That's another Claire Keegan tenet—you're spinning a world and your reader is trusting you, but if you have even one moment where your reader pulls their head out of the world, looks around their living room and says, "I don't believe you," then the whole project is a failure.

AG: I would say the more straightforward your plot chronology is the less you need to rely on chapter labels to do story work. I just read Liz Moore's *The God of the Woods* which has one of the more complicated labeling schemes I've seen. Though it calls attention to the book as a constructed object, the chapter headings are also very helpful, perhaps indispensable to the reader's comprehension. They also streamline the writing. Moore didn't have to clue readers

into time shifts within the scene. The chapter headings took care of that. Did you give much thought to the fact that as an epistolary novel, you're labeling system is built in? Date. Salutation. Closing. Emails are time stamped.

VE: No. Later somebody mentioned that I didn't have to create chapter breaks because the letters are the chapters, and that was the first time I had thought about it. As a reader I really enjoy page breaks. I think every reader is reading for that pause, even if you're completely compelled by the book and going on to the next page right away. Books with long chapters can feel exhausting. We should exercise those muscles and read those kinds of books, but this book—and any epistolary novel—gives the reader more frequent satisfaction. Metaphorically speaking, as you read, you're holding your breath. When you get a chapter break you get to release it and take a new breath. I think that's part of the reason my book is appealing to people. It feels easy to get through even if it's an average length.

AG: There are a lot of plot threads in this novel. Did the epistolary form make it easier or more difficult to include so much?

VE: I know it's crazy when you list them.

AG: That's what's so impressive about your talent.

VE: The form did make it easier. In a traditional narrative, once you introduce a plot point and character, you create an expectation in the reader. You're on the hook for the whole story. But in an epistolary novel, the letters are not the story. The story of these people's lives is happening outside their letters. For example, when Harry runs away from home, walks to Sybil's house with his dog, and ends up living with her for six months and helping her with one of her problems, I didn't have to tell that story. What I told was the story of how Sybil relayed those events to others in her letters. In some ways the book is the scaffolding of a very complex story, but for some reason it's gratifying. I think it's because the scaffolding all relates to Sybil, the person you are most interested in. You want to understand why is she so grumpy and weird and tortured? That's what's driving you through the story. Using the vehicle of letters also gave me freedom. For example, early in the book she writes to The Baltimore Sun to criticize them for printing a story about a parent who accidentally ran over their child. That is the end of the thread. Nothing more comes of that letter, but it does prove to be an important part of building Sybil for the reader. Another example is learning her neighbor's Holocaust story. You care about the neighbor because his experiences tell you something about why he and Sybil connect so deeply.

AG: By providing these other character's stories, you illuminate Sybil without explaining her to us, which might be the book's core brilliance. It reminds me of a quote in an Emily Dickinson poem.

Tell all the truth but tell it slant —

Success in Circuit lies

VE: I wouldn't try to write Sybil's story directly. I don't want to read that novel if I'm being honest. I don't want to have to zoom in on her pain like that. But I do want to tell that story and so it is a question of how I could do it in a way that feels life-affirming. Her age provides that angle. I don't believe time heals all wounds, but there is something about time that provides a distance and that's the only angle that I would have ever written this story from.

AG: Did you start with Sybil's greatest pain?

VE: Yes. I knew I wanted her to be somebody who had lived with long grief.

AG: In a traditional narrative, an author writes dramatic scenes. They show the big moments, not tell them. With an epistolary novel, it's the opposite. Everything going on in Sybil's life at the present moment, including her ongoing grief, occurs "off stage" as I call it. You tell everything, even the big plot points, and you have to tell them slant, through one character relating them to another, or referring to them obliquely because both characters already know about the events. It's like sex in a novel. Writing it directly is nearly impossible, so we write the lead up and the aftermath. That's what these letters do. For example, when Sybil tells Theo about her greatest secret, we don't see that. We infer it by their subsequent letters, and we know how he reacted only by implication. As you were writing, did you think about the advantages and disadvantages of dealing with highly emotional material this way?

VE: It's so interesting to talk to people who are reading the book critically because as a writer I'm just trying to tell a good story and figure out what makes you want to keep reading. I only see that I'm working via scaffolding or telling a story off-stage in hindsight. It's more evident to me now that it was a challenging thing to attempt. I've written traditional books before, so this was definitely something new, but I didn't think too hard about it. I just dove in and tried to find my way through. I definitely had some critical reads from people I trust that I had to move things around, the timing of certain things had to change. It wasn't like it came together magically on the first try, but I try really hard not to overthink because then I'd get scared and wouldn't write at all.

AG: At the end of the book, readers get to see a letter Sybil tried to write but never sent. It's key emotionally to bringing the book to a close. Can you tell me a little about how that came about?

VE: I'm pretty sure that's how I ended the first draft. I wanted to show something that felt like a new revelation on the last page, which turned out to be how Sybil labored over her letters, crossed out and fixed words. It leaves you with the question of whether she did that with all her letters. It showed her humanity from another angle. In the finished letters she is articulate and put together, so sure of who she is, but that letter shows she was afraid and working hard to make her image. Her life was long and things turned out in some ways well, but I didn't want to end that way. I wanted the last taste in your mouth to be the grief she had to live with. It was always going to be both joy and sorrow. That's how life really is.

AG: Sybil reads novels and corresponds with some real-life writers, including Joan Didion. How did you have the courage to write letters in Didion's voice?

VE: That's the best question I've been asked. After we sold it, I asked, "Is this okay?" It's legally permitted because she's deceased. I haven't had any fallout from readers, but I've said in interviews: "What kind of asinine craziness is it to write as Joan Didion?" I did it originally because I didn't think I was going to show this book to anyone. I wasn't planning on giving it to my agent or selling it, so I wrote recklessly about a lot of things, including writing in the voice of a Syrian refugee.

AG: Maybe the epistolary form helped. Basam, the Syrian refugee, isn't the main character so you're not getting deep into his life experience. You are only imagining what he might write in a narrow context to Sybil.

VE: Right. These days fiction writers are terrified to write things that are not our own personal life experience, which I think is a problem in the current landscape. Should I only write about white women in their 30s for the rest of my life? How boring. But that's my life experience. Not thinking I would show this book to anyone gave me the guts to do a lot of things I probably wouldn't have done if I felt like somebody was reading over my shoulder, which is a life lesson for me—just write freely.

Author Biography

Virginia Evans attended James Madison University for her bachelor's in English literature. After starting a family, she went back to school for her master's of philosophy in creative writing at Trinity College in Dublin, Ireland, where she had the good fortune to study under Carlo Gébler, Eoin McNamee, Claire Keegan, Harry Clifton and Kevin Power. She now lives in Winston-Salem, North Carolina, with her husband, Mark, two children, Jack and Mae, and her Red Labrador, Brigid.

Reviews

Library Journal

Evans's heartfelt debut, told through a series of marvelous letters, gets to the heart of the human connection. Sybil Van Antwerp is a complex figure: a 73-year-old retired lawyer, literary enthusiast, mother, grandmother, ex-wife, sister, adopted daughter, and, above all, dedicated pen pal. She is fiercely stubborn, thoughtful, and blunt; to her great dismay, she is gradually losing her eyesight. Sybil's life story is beautifully told through letters exchanged between her and a range of characters, expertly narrated in this audiobook by a large cast of seasoned voice actors. Sybil corresponds with a staggering variety of people: well-known authors (including Ann Patchett, Larry McMurtry, and Joan Didion), her caring neighbor, family members, friends, professors, long-lost relatives, customer service representatives, and a mysterious, disgruntled person from her past. Each letter is unique, a compelling monologue that communicates raw emotion and grief alongside humor and tart observations. Every missive offers glimpses into the characters' lives, allowing listeners to get to know them through their pieced-together exchanges. VERDICT Evans's epistolary novel is funny and dear, with a family drama and a bit of mystery too. It is a treasure.

Kirkus Reviews

A lifetime's worth of letters combine to portray a singular character. Sybil Van Antwerp, a cantankerous but exceedingly well-mannered septuagenarian, is the titular correspondent in Evans' debut novel. Sybil has retired from a beloved job as chief clerk to a judge with whom she had previously been in private legal practice. She is the divorced mother of two living adult children and one who died when he was 8. She is a reader of novels, a gardener, and a keen observer of human nature. But the most distinguishing thing about Sybil is her lifelong practice of letter writing. As advancing vision problems threaten Sybil's carefully constructed way of life--in which letters take the place of personal contact and engagement--she must reckon with unaddressed issues from her past that threaten the house of cards (letters, really) she has built around herself. Sybil's relationships are gradually revealed in the series of letters sent to and received from, among others, her brother, sister-in-law, children, former work associates, and, 2 intriguingly, literary icons including Joan Didion and Larry McMurtry. Perhaps most affecting is the series of missives Sybil writes but never mails to a shadowy figure from her past. Thoughtful musings on the value and immortal quality of letters and the written word populate one of Sybil's notes to a young correspondent while other messages are laugh-out-loud funny, tinged with her characteristic blunt tartness. Evans has created a brusque and quirky yet endearing main character with no shortage of opinions and advice for others but who fails to excavate the knotty difficulties of her own life. As Sybil grows into a delayed self-awareness, her letters serve as a chronicle of fitful growth. An affecting portrait of a prickly woman.

Read-Alikes

The Collected Regrets of Clover by Mikki Brammer

Mikki Brammer's *The Collected Regrets of Clover* is a big-hearted and life-affirming debut about a death doula who, in caring for others at the end of their life, has forgotten how to live her own. What's the point of giving someone a beautiful death if you can't give yourself a beautiful life? From the day she watched her kindergarten teacher drop dead during a dramatic telling of *Peter Rabbit*, Clover Brooks has felt a stronger connection with the dying than she has with the living. After the beloved grandfather who raised her dies alone while she is traveling, Clover becomes a death doula in New York City, dedicating her life to ushering people peacefully through their end-of-life process. Clover spends so much time with the dying that she has no life of her own, until the final wishes of a feisty old woman send Clover on a trip across the country to uncover a forgotten love story--and perhaps, her own happy ending. As she finds herself struggling to navigate the uncharted roads of romance and friendship, Clover is forced to examine what she really wants, and whether she'll have the courage to go after it. Probing, clever, and hopeful, *The Collected Regrets of Clover* turns the normally taboo subject of death into a reason to celebrate life.

The Authenticity Project by Clare Pooley

Everybody lies about their lives. What would happen if you shared the truth?' This is the question that Julian Jessop, an eccentric, seventy-nine-year-old artist, poses within a pale green exercise book that he labels *The Authenticity Project*, before leaving it behind in Monica's Café. When Monica discovers Julian's abandoned notebook, not only does she add her own story to the book, she is determined to find a way to help Julian feel less lonely. And so it goes with the others who find the green notebook that will soon contain their deepest selves. It will also knit the group together *In Real Life* at Monica's Cafe, where they'll discover the thrill and sometime-risk of being completely honest--and, for some, find unexpected love.